



Course Evaluations Spring 2024, period 2

Course Director Report 5329 Inequality, Household Behavior, & the Macroeconomy



Report prepared by **Quality Assurance**
Created **Friday, June 7, 2024**



Courses Audience: 32
Responses Received: 18
Response Ratio: 56.25%

Report Comments

The content of this report is intended for the course director. Please be cautious when discussing the results and do not distribute the report outside the School. The Stockholm School of Economics is committed to ensuring the protection of personal data and the integrity of students and employees.

All ratings are on a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 is “disagree strongly” and 7 is “agree strongly”.

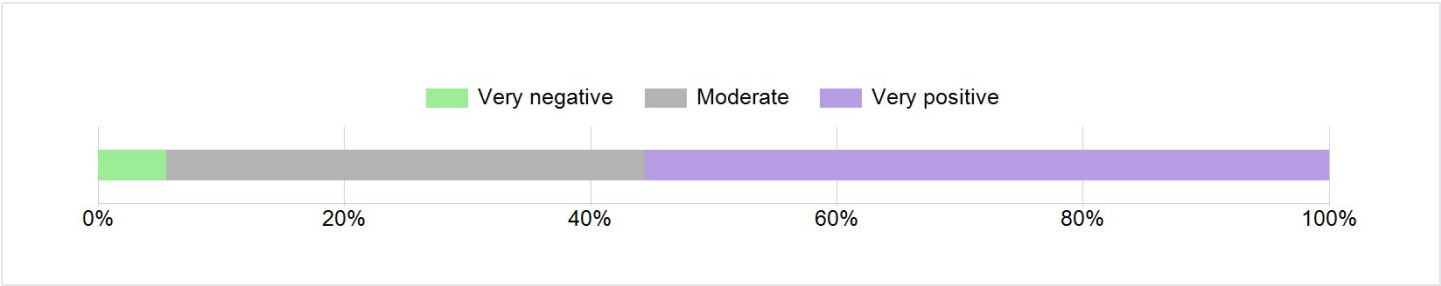
The total teacher average is calculated regardless of the number of responses to each question. This means that the three teacher-related questions have the same weight.

N.B. If there are course feedback surveys closing after the end of the current study period, this report might be updated.

If this report is for a mandatory course in one of SSE's programs, this report will also be shared with the program director directly.

Please contact SSEquality@hhs.se if you have any questions.

Course Satisfaction (scale distribution)



Course Satisfaction

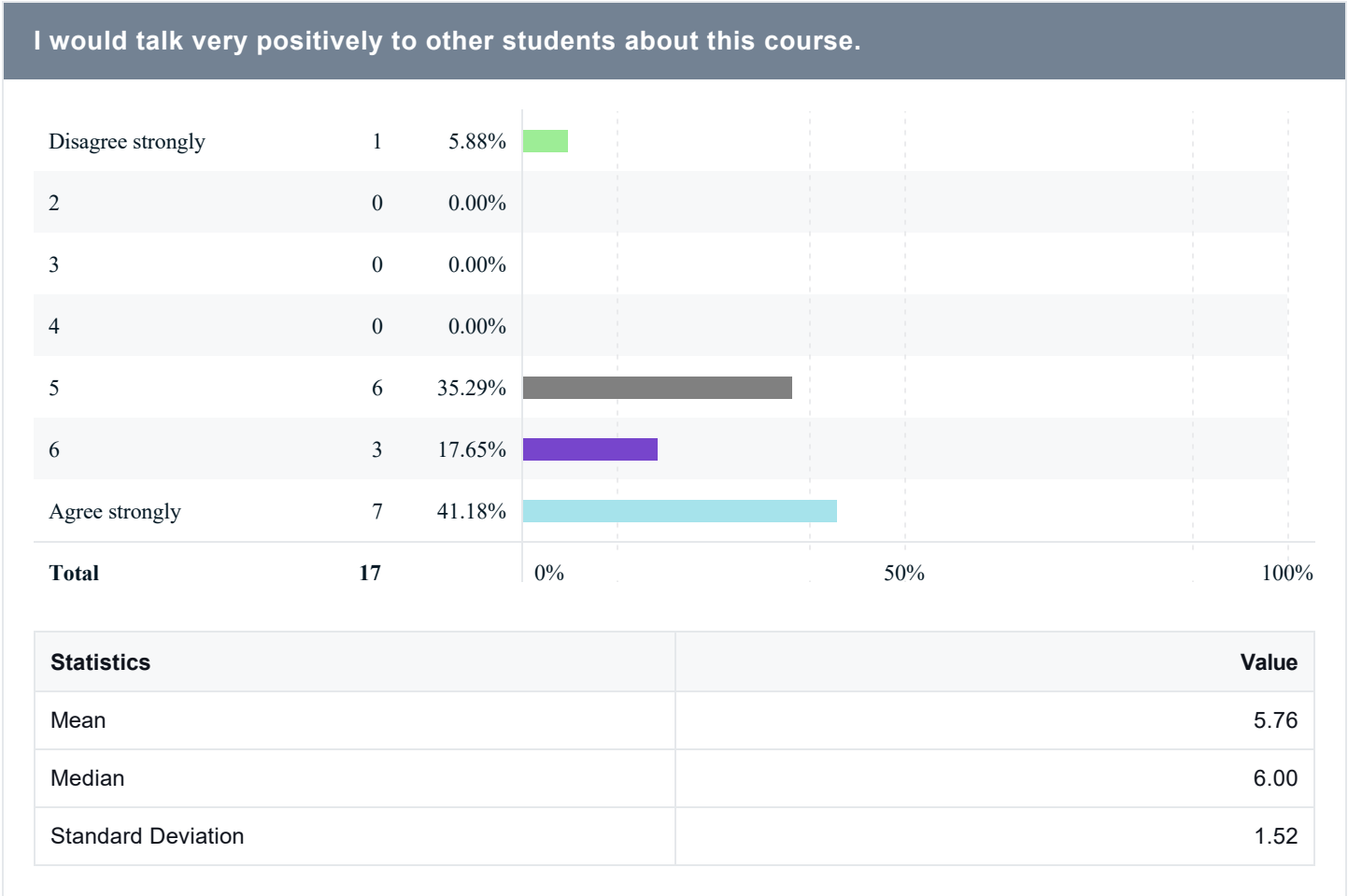
Overall, I am satisfied with the quality of this course.

Disagree strongly	0	0.00%	
2	1	5.56%	
3	0	0.00%	
4	0	0.00%	
5	7	38.89%	
6	4	22.22%	
Agree strongly	6	33.33%	
Total	18	0%	100%

Statistics	Value
Mean	5.72
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.27

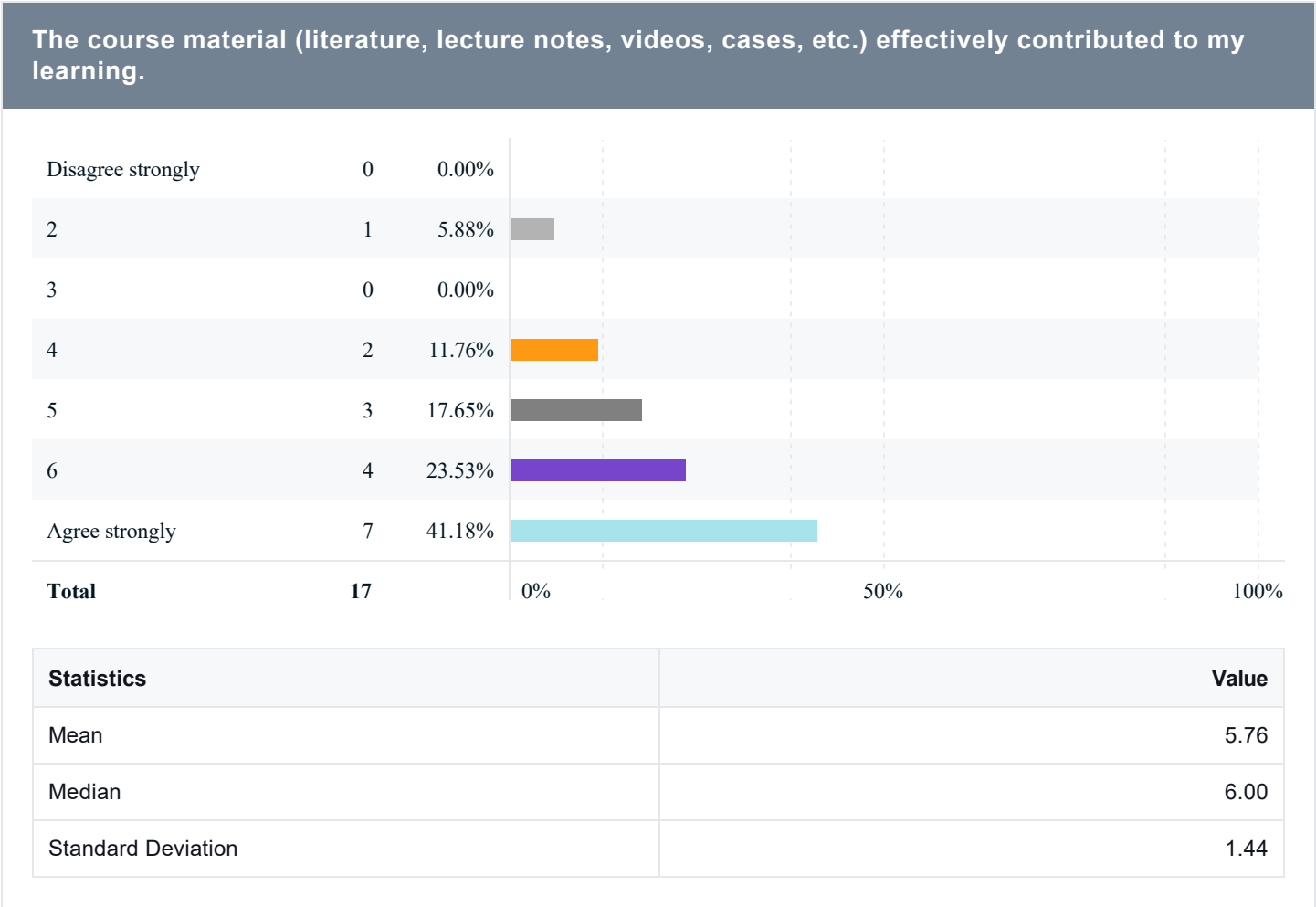
SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.45	1.50	1188

I would talk very positively to other students about this course.



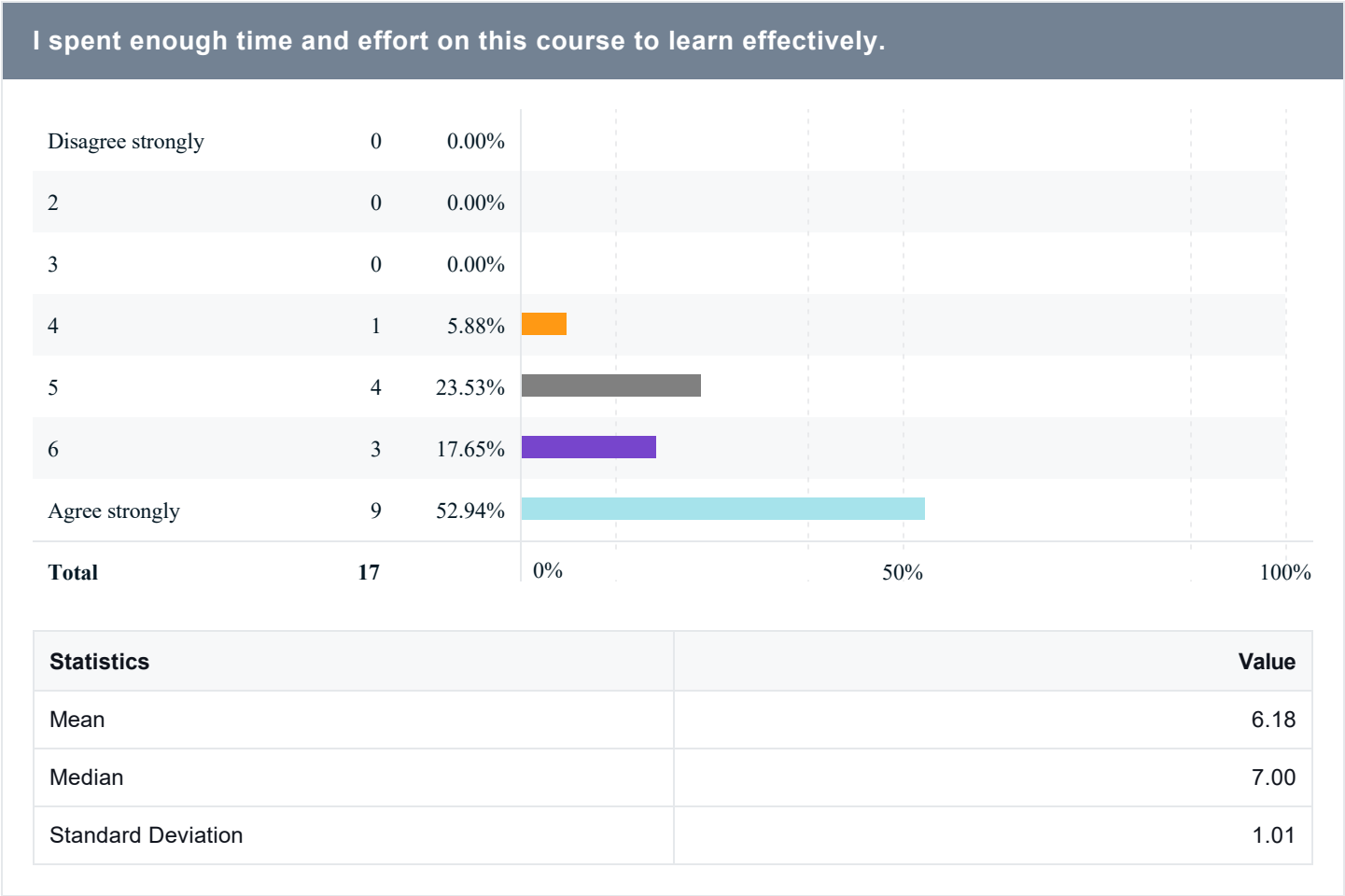
SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.42	1.61	1139

Course Material



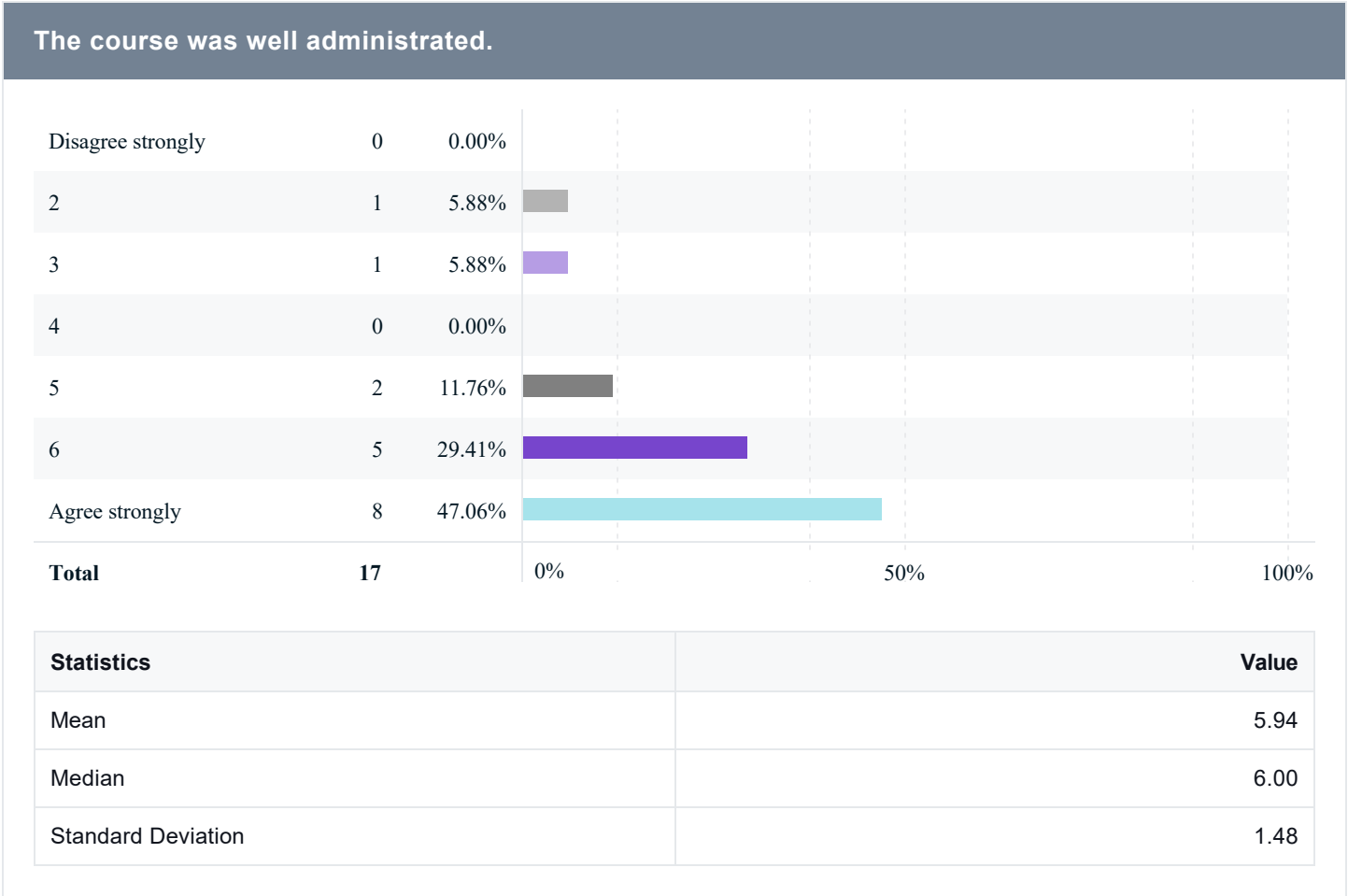
SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.33	1.54	1141

Time Spent on Course



SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.64	1.32	1136

Administration



SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.75	1.46	1138

Do you have any specific feedback on the course administration?

Comments
Provide more examples of exams since all assignments were 80–90% coding, there was a general consensus even one week before the exam that no one knew what to expect.
No not really
Assignment solutions were not uploaded when the solutions were discussed throughout the term despite repeated requests to the TA.

What were the strengths of this course? Please be specific and use concrete examples where possible.

Comments
I found the course to be pretty advanced in some parts which was interesting
The programming. Zoltan really enjoys the programming, so do I. It is a relatively heavy programming course for us Econ-people.
The topic of inequality is interesting in its own right
Good teacher! Provide systematic content about inequality. Also provide a good way to learn coding.
Strong macroeconomic theory foundations. Applied course to real life events and data. Allowed to develop coding Skills. It was the first time I have learned how to solve complex macro economic models using real life data and coding. This was an unique characteristic of the course wich is extremely valuable to finally apply economic theory andlearn how to develop models that adjustto empirical evidence. Theprofessor andTA were extremely committed to students, answering questions, motivating the lectures and . always caringthat students understand the theory/ codes.
This was my favorite course so far in MECON. Thanks to the coding that we did, I was able to understand economic models and parameters in much more depth than I ever have before! The lectures were well prepared and always had a clear logic and order that made difficult topics as easy as possible to digest.
I believe that this course was great in several aspects. First of all, Zoltan and John both did an amazing job and were both very helpful throughout the entire course. I think the assignments were well set up and connected to the content in the lectures and the exam. I also think the exam was very fair and what we students expected.
Found the empirical aspects of the course really interesting. Was exposed to more advanced modeling for the first time and am sure to apply this knowledge for my thesis.
Introduction to Julia and focus on empirical applications
Zoltan is super nice and very helpful and ready to adapt to our questions and learning pace
The course was interesting and offered excellent learning opportunities. I particularly appreciated the extensive use of the Julia programming language for assignments, which improved my technical skills. Although challenging, the assignments were valuable for practicing coding and analytical abilities. The lectures were both interesting and informative. Coding files included detailed comments to avoid confusion, which was very helpful. The teachers were consistently available to answer questions through office hours and emails. Overall, it was evident that the course director, Zoltan Racz, dedicated a great deal of effort to teaching this course.
1. Zoltan was very approachable and friendly throughout the course. Questions asked would be replied to within a few hours which was greatly appreciated. 2. Great exposure to research papers in the field and concepts like the Bellman equation 3. Good introduction to Julia and the course highlighted well why Julia specifically was useful in the models we were implementing rather than any other programming language.
The material and topics were really interesting once you actually understood what was going on.
Interesting content, good assignments, good teachers, well planned and interesting lectures. I really want Zoltan to know that he did a great job for his first course! :) This is for sure one of my favorite courses yet in the mecon program and one that feels very useful

How could this course be improved? Please be specific and use concrete examples where possible.

Comments

I do not think the assignments helped me learn. In my group no one was great at coding. Even with the Julia tutorial, partly pre-written code, and help from teachers and class mates, 90% of time spent on the assignments was just trying to get the code to work and figuring out what we were supposed to do with the code.

I think that two things would have drastically improved the course: 1) Make the assignment questions MUCH clearer, both wrt to the code but also the math questions. No one understood what "Which quantities are used to discipline the two Φ parameters..." meant.

2) The assignments unfortunately did not help us learn much intuition. We simply tried to explain why graphs looked the way they did, which does not require much knowledge of the course material in my opinion. I believe that it would be better to have seminars on assigned reading where we argue for/against findings/models in the papers, or get to present the findings of some papers.

Make it a course on only programming, or only in inequality. Now it feels a bit like it tries to be both, however I like it.

Focus more on the actual content of the course and the topics, lessen the focus on coding. For a course that isn't supposed to be a coding course, I feel that the only thing I have learnt is to code rather than advance my knowledge on these topics.

Homework is a bit too complex.

Time constraints to focus on how to learn from scratch writing the codes to solve these models.

More discussions regarding models, theory and results. Would be nice to dedicate some time to discuss the papers we have read in class or the results from the models, to develop critical thinking. Also during the seminars would be nice to discuss potential scenarios, to discuss more about the models and complexities regarding the codes to prepare ourselves for working with Macroeconomic models.

I found the homework workload of this course to be excessive, and it made it difficult to keep up with my other course. I think that future students could cover the same ground (i.e. write the same code, do the same interpretation) in a much more reasonable time requirement if they were given more hints on how to work with the code in the problem set (e.g. how to call a value function, how to find out what your highest and lowest alpha values are). So much of our time on the problem sets was spent merely figuring out details of Julia rather than generating results and understanding the intuition.

The only thing I can think of is that it would have been nice to have gotten access to the assignments a bit earlier so that we had a bit more time to work on them, especially the last one before the exam.

Felt like there was little information on how the exam will look like. Could be nice to be a bit clearer on that.

Use Python instead of Julia, the Assignments are super super hard

Even though I had a great experience learning Julia, I would have appreciated putting this level of effort into working with a more popular and in-demand programming language, such as Python.

1. Repeated revisions of slides due to errors or additions was very hard to keep track of and maintaining two versions is annoying (as the classroom notes are on the original pdf). High chance of missing out on something while revising for the exam.
2. The assignments were extremely difficult and stressful. More guidance on those should be provided and/or more lenient grading.
3. More exercises for practice to do well on the assignments and the exam.
4. A textbook should be assigned for the course as the slides are very brief and it would be helpful to have a resource you could go back to for a deeper understanding. The research papers obviously do not explain all the concepts and hence a textbook/s would be extremely beneficial.

Comments

I think for the amount of time and the fact that we are taking 2 courses at the same time, the work load has been too high. Especially considering the amount of time that we put into the problem sets and then some of the questions/graphs etc turned out to not require an answer (like the value function, or weird kinks in some graphs) or turns out you couldn't interpret a coefficient. After having spent hours and hours on something this is very frustrating.

The only issue I had was one of my group members did not even try learning Julia (which is essentially mandatory for the assignment since there is no way I would be able to translate the code that was given to us to any other programming language) which made it so that I had to pull a large weight in the group project where I had to do most of the programming myself which was a bit stressful. This is not really any fault of the course though, but perhaps there could be a bit more encouragement to get everyone involved in trying to learn Julia somehow such that you don't end up with groups where one person has to do most of it.

What would you like to tell future students about this course?

Comments
I'm glad I took the course but do not take the course if you do not feel very comfortable with coding.
It's a lot of programming, more real programming than just R.
Unless the course curriculum changes I would advise them to take another course, unless they truly love learning new coding languages.
Take it!
It is one of the most interesting and complete/applied curses I have ever taken. Plus it is a smart choice to take this course If you like macroeconomic theory or you are interested in inequality or wellbeing. Plus, learning new coding programmes it is always a plus for professional development.
Take it! (and invest the time at the beginning to understand how EconPars, solve, and simulate work...)
That it is a very good course to take if you like a mix of qualitative and quantitative studies. I would also tell them that the Professor and the TA are really helpful and do their very best at making us understand and taking their time to explain all concepts in the course.
Take the course if you're interested in advancing your knowledge on the topics covered in the macro course in a more applied fashion. An interest in coding is beneficial.
it was great!
This is a very heavy course. You need to know a lot of programming, a lot of Economic concepts /intuition, AND a lot of math (at least for someone without a math background). So it really can be quite tough, but in the end it's a very interesting course and the things you learn actually seem applicable and relevant especially compared to a lot of other Economics courses at SEE
Take this course!!!

Teacher Questions

Q1: The teacher effectively advanced and facilitated my learning.
Q2: I received the help I needed from the teacher in an appropriate time frame.
Total: Overall of All Questions

If no tables are displayed in this section, no teacher-specific questions were included in the survey.

Teacher Zoltan Racz

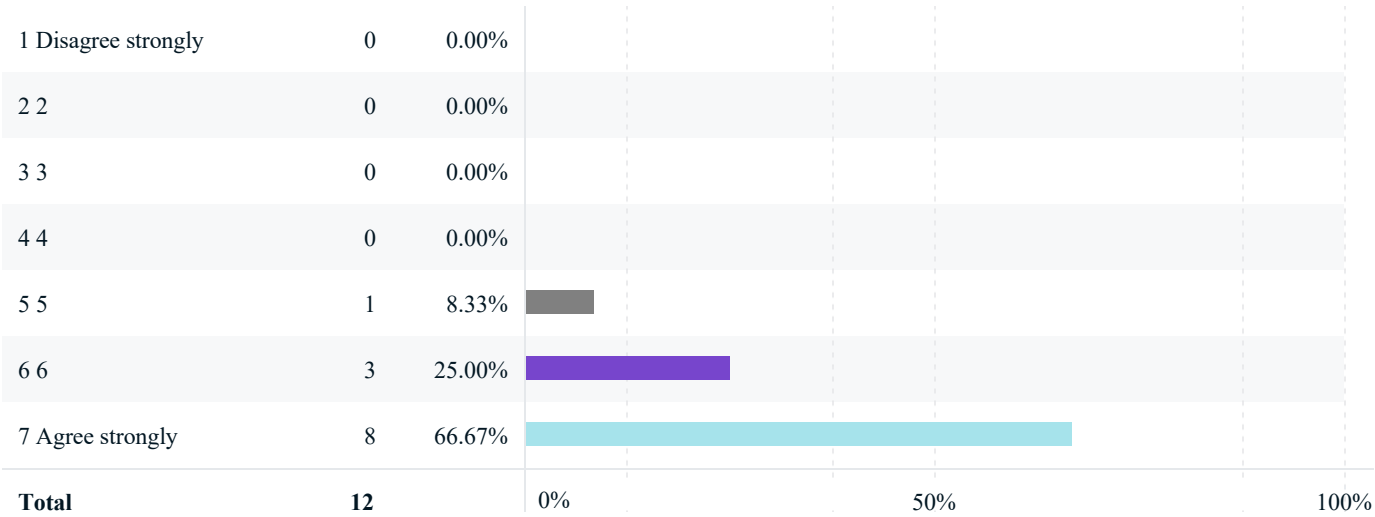
	Q1			Q2		
	Mean	SD	Resp	Mean	SD	Resp
Overall	6.11	0.96	18	6.59	0.71	17

SSE Average, Spring 24

	Q1			Q2		
	Mean	SD	Resp	Mean	SD	Resp
Overall	5.77	1.51	1696	6.02	1.41	1492

Equality and Diversity

In this course, the teacher(s) actively worked to include different people and perspectives. This was demonstrated in, for example, the selection of course materials, case studies and/or guest speakers as well as during lectures and classroom discussions through balanced speaking time and avoiding stereotypical examples.



Statistics	Value
Mean	6.58
Median	7.00
Standard Deviation	0.67

SSE Average	Mean	SD	Resp
Spring 24	5.93	1.35	1054

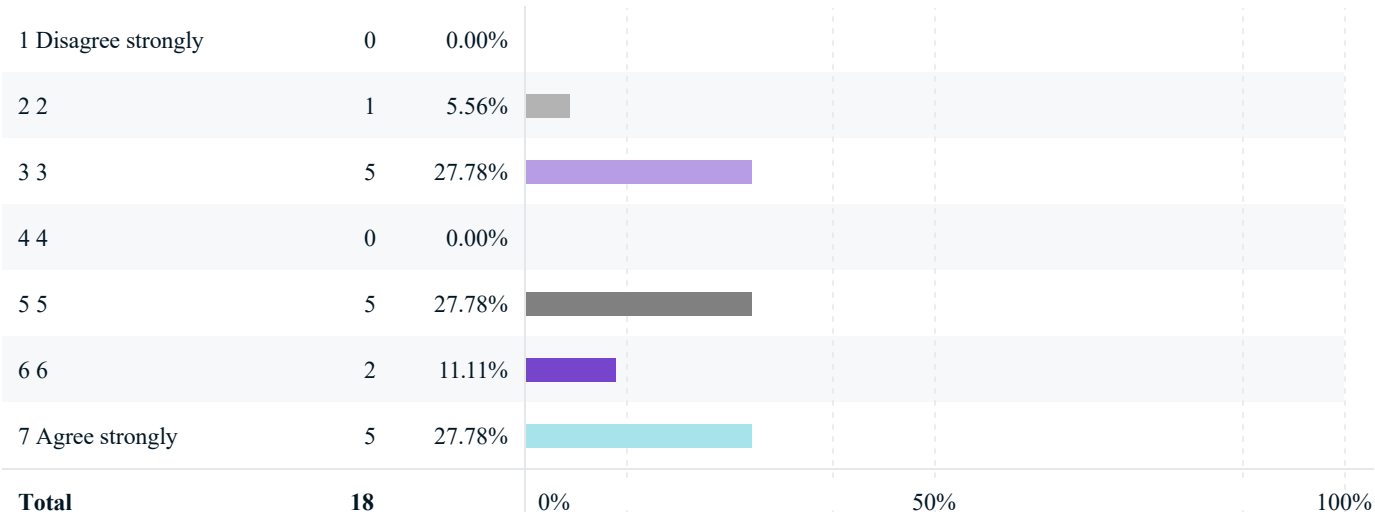
What concrete, constructive suggestions do you have for integrating a diversity, equity and inclusion perspective in this course?

Note: Course evaluations are confidential. If you would like to report a specific incident, please send an [e-mail to Karol Vieker](#), the Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Manager at SSE. Your e-mail will be handled in strict confidence. You can also use the anonymous whistleblowing tool <https://hhs.whistlelink.com/>.

Comments
I cannot see any link between diversity, equity and inclusion and macroeconomics and learning to code in Julia.
None
Nothing more than what is already being done really.

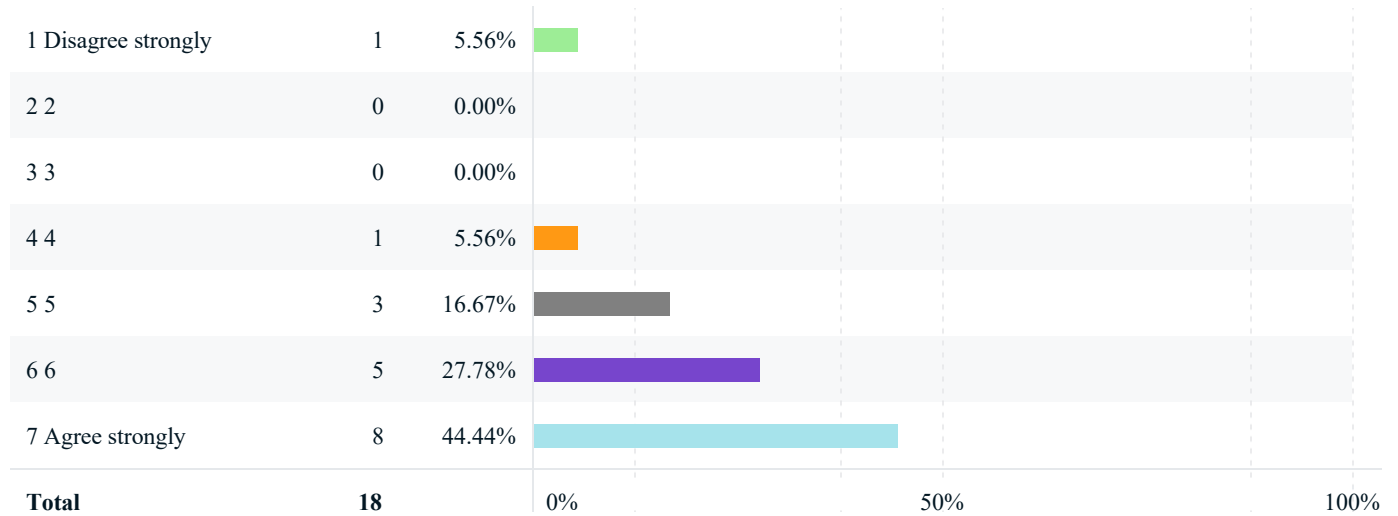
Course Questions

1. The course workload and requirements were appropriate for the course level.



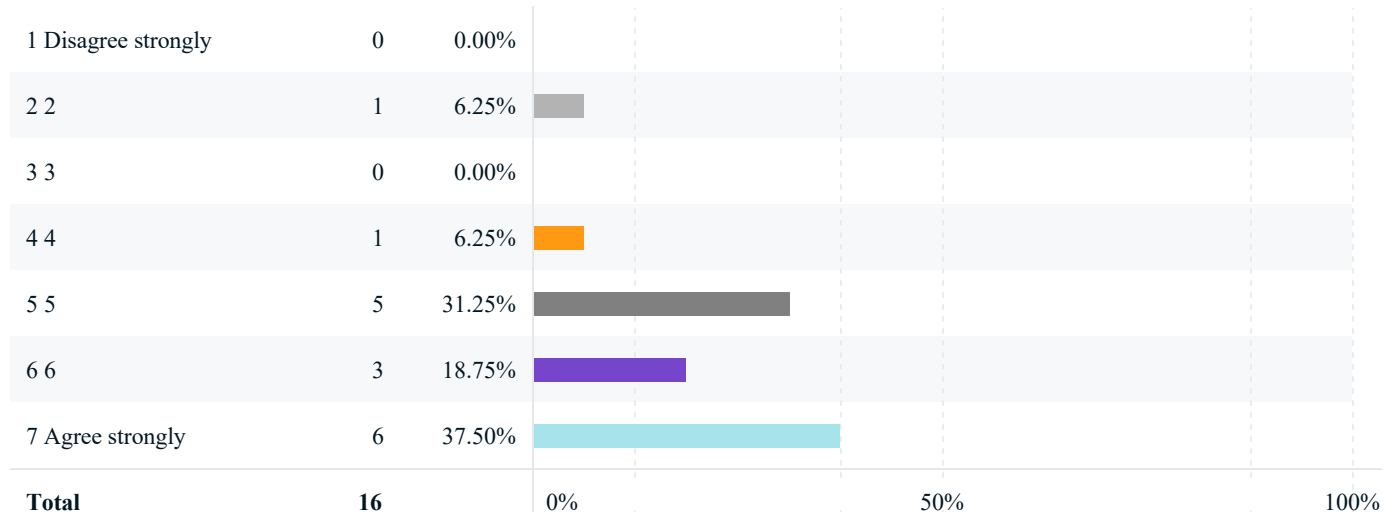
Statistics	Value
Mean	4.94
Median	5.00
Standard Deviation	1.73

2. I have developed valuable expertise/skills during the course.



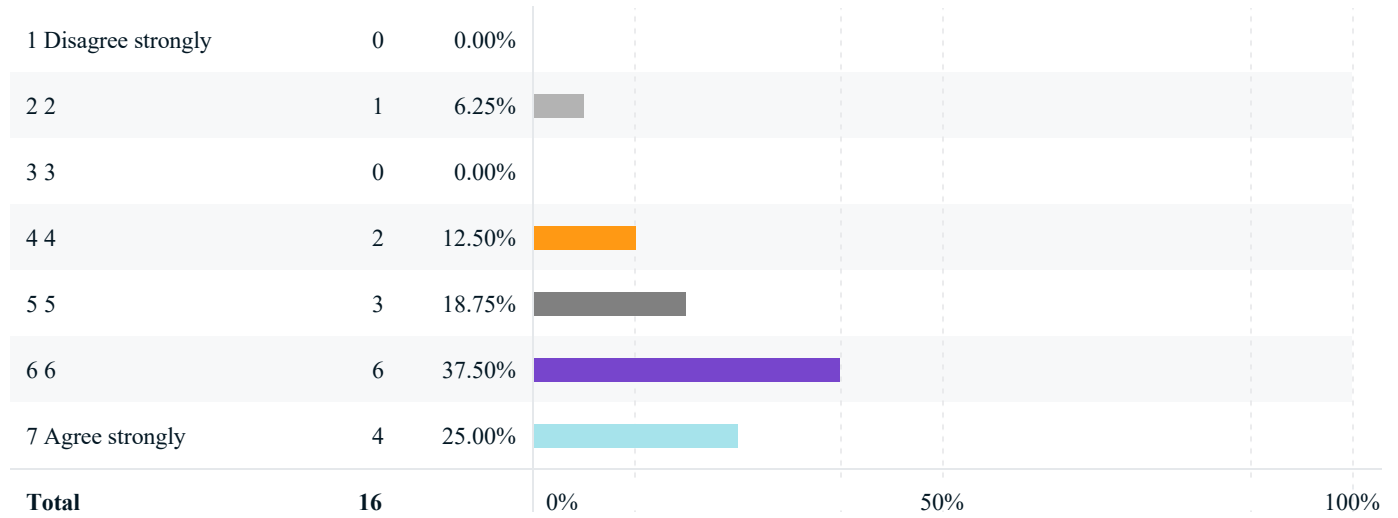
Statistics	Value
Mean	5.89
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.53

3. The support my teaching assistant(s) provided contributed to my learning in the course.



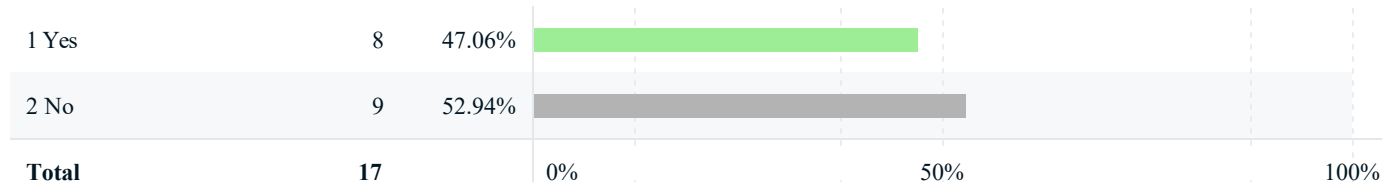
Statistics	Value
Mean	5.69
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.40

4. The tutorial sessions contributed to my learning experience in the course.



Statistics	Value
Mean	5.56
Median	6.00
Standard Deviation	1.36

The tempo of this course was challenging to follow.



Statistics	Value
Mean	1.53
Median	2.00
Standard Deviation	0.51

Comment
- Learning to code in yet another language
- Not really, I am a MECON students so the "hard parts" with a lot of maths was already familiar to us.
- no
- Working with Julia was challenging due to my lack of experience in coding. Nevertheless, I appreciated the opportunity to develop new technical skills.
- Both programming and some mathematics. Luckily I had others in my group with experience so I could focus more on Economic intuition. But it seemed very unfair towards those who did not have that.
- The programming was challenging, but it was really nice to have the first few lectures going through the language and I think we had a lot of help to get us through it